

May I Share a Park Bench with You? – Horizontalizing through Encounters with the Duck

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Figure 1: The benches are popular spaces among the park's waterfowl.

Abstract

Co-existing in more-than-human cities requires a shift from the anthropocentric methods of design. This paper details our experiences from a residency in a city park, where we conducted design explorations to share a bench with a Duck. As more-than-human design gains traction, HCI is developing new methods and positionalities. We use Wakkary's design-with [65] to critically reflect on our process with the Duck. Through the concept of horizontality, we account for a repositioning of the human designer alongside other more-than-human beings, moving away from dominant human perspectives in design processes and becoming posthuman subjects. We contribute with an example of working with horizontality, providing additional nuances and insights. We offer three additional dimensions: **spatial**, **agential**, and **temporal horizontality**. Finally, we discuss ideas to further mobilize the concept and the potential of asking polite questions to non-humans.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → Interaction design; Interaction design process and methods.

Keywords

More-than-human, posthuman subject, horizontality, co-habitation, duck

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1 Introduction

A feral Muscovy Duck has settled in a city park with some other feathery beings. It is not a rare sight in Amsterdam, where one can see ducks, geese, or coots in almost every canal or park. What is not so common is how this specific Duck ended up in a paper about human-computer interaction. This work emerges from a residency project where the first author, Ege, set out to investigate how the space in the park is shared by herself and the Duck. The starting point was a question to the Duck: May I share a park bench with you? Ege committed to asking this question for six weeks but never succeeded in sharing the park bench. While this investigation was not initially intended to be an academic paper, we wondered: what can we, as HCI researchers, learn about our more-than-human entanglements from engaging in unsuccessful pursuits with ducks?

As wildlife habitats are shrinking due to extreme weather events caused by the climate crisis and an ever-expanding urban landscape, the sightings of wild animals in cities are becoming increasingly frequent [2, 67]. Complex entanglements between different bodies are often discussed in critical posthumanist and feminist theory [8, 27, 63]. Human-constructed divisions between humans and non-humans are challenged not only ontologically but also in city

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planning, resulting mostly in interspecies conflicts that initiate the need for finding alternative ways of co-existing. It has become urgent to understand and comply with these entanglements in the everyday life of cities. To co-exist in a more-than-human world, designers need to create systems, infrastructures, services, and things that consider more-than-human beings. This motivates a shift from anthropocentric thinking in design [20, 21, 25, 36, 65]. HCI researchers have explored concepts and methods such as noticing [37–39], more-than-human care [33, 46, 51, 57], repertoires [4, 49], removal [28], non-human personas [62] or thing ethnography [24]. Yet, there is also an emerging need to look at research practices differently, particularly the changing position of researchers in becoming posthuman subjects who are themselves open and porous to more-than-human perspectives and ways of knowing.

To come back to the *feathery* beings in Amstelpark, Amsterdam (Figure 1), the Duck¹ caught Ege's attention at the start of the residency. For six weeks, Ege explored her entanglements with this specific Duck while trying to share a park bench. Although it may seem simple, committing to it for six weeks enabled Ege a generative space. In this paper, we present our analysis of Ege's experiences from her attempts to design for sharing space with the Duck, focusing on her positionality as the human designer. In our analysis, we apply the lens of horizontality as proposed by Wakkary [65], which accounts for the repositioning of the human designer alongside other more-than-human beings. The designer as a posthuman subject, according to Wakkary, is relational and expansive of humans and non-humans that are part of the design process. To move away from dominant human perspectives in design processes, Wakkary suggests adapting generosity as a combination of relationality and expansiveness and sees horizontality as a "*metaphor for embodied generosity*" [65:251].

Offered as a starting point, horizontality is still quite open as a term or concept. We saw an opportunity to explore it through this project: to find specificity and nuance and to understand its potential and setbacks. In this paper, we use horizontality as a lens to reflect on Ege's process with the Duck. We use it to critically reflect on Ege's activities, highlight what we have learned and unlearned through them and how they transformed Ege as a designer. Specifically, we ask: **how can horizontality help design researchers in becoming posthuman subjects?** With this, we contribute to the previous work in more-than-human design and help carve out horizontality as a concept for designers to use in future research.

2 RELATED WORK

2.1 One Duck in Amsterdam

Multispecies interaction is increasingly gaining interest in HCI, with researchers investigating computation in the lives of animals

[41], including ethical and playful use of technology [22, 23] and interaction with animals in different spaces, from homes [35] to zoos [34]. A wider scope of living bodies and their entanglements with their environment is addressed in HCI research that aims to understand cities as multispecies environments [10, 13–15, 32, 54, 56, 64, 66]. For example, Smith et al. introduce the concepts of *naturecultures* and *hybrids* as scaffolds for decentering the human in design [56]. Clarke brings attention to urban interdependencies of more-than-human in her performative and participatory walks while wearing masks of various animals that no longer reside in cities [13]. Cucumak and Subaşı investigate stray animals and their relationship with the city through an extensive photo-visual study [15], and Wakkary et al. design-with the ambivalence of interacting with native bees in Vancouver [64]. We position our work within this emerging area, focusing on alternative forms of multispecies cohabitation. In our work, we aim to highlight the role of non-humans as *individuals* in research. Many of the previous examples focus on species or categories, such as "dogs" or "stray animals." While this sensemaking categorization is understandable, it also risks rendering the non-human individuals of that group as others, anonymous and/or generalized. We present our work with *one* Duck, acknowledging the Duck's key position and individuality in this research.

2.2 Sharing a horizon with the Duck

Designing with more-than-human worlds broadens the scope of HCI to include multispecies interactions [37, 56, 64], micro-organisms [7, 45], sensors [44], materials [49], things [24], and spirits [1]. This shift also challenges the position of human designers. *Decentering* has been a key interest in more-than-human design research [20, 21, 25, 36, 65] through which dominant human roles, perspectives, and agencies are questioned. However, decentering remains a challenge and can create uncomfortable feelings [6]. It is impossible to decenter ourselves completely, as our cognitive capacities are inherently human [40, 49]. Livio and Devendorf suggest looking at decentering as "*a horizon to guide movement that is concurrently understood to remain continually beyond reach*" [40:10]. Similarly, Nicenboim et al. trace the notion by synthesizing the theory with practical exemplars and position it as an ongoing practice [42]. We adopt this perspective and aim to follow a humble approach in which we revisit our process of sharing space with the Duck. We use the lens of horizontality, a concept from Wakkary's *design-with* [65] to further challenge the dominant and hierarchical positioning of humans in design. Through this analysis, we elaborate on how our positionality as the human designer changed. We will elaborate more in the third section on how we work with the concept.

2.3 We will never fully know the Duck

Design research is not linear, and scholars have started developing approaches and lenses to explore the research process in a more nuanced and authentic way, embracing its uncertainties. Many see it as a path and turn towards reflective analyses using first-person methods [12, 31, 45, 51, 61], paying attention to decay [58], tangents [16], tensions [48], fragilities [50], or rethinking what failure means [29, 59]. These approaches help uncover insights that

¹Throughout this paper, the Duck is always referred to with a capital D. The naming of the Duck has gone through various stages throughout the project and remains challenging. First, the residency participants often misidentified the Duck for a goose and therefore it was referred to in the group as such. After Ege found out that the Duck is a Muscovy Duck species, she took on the task of correcting other residents. When Ege started her work, others often asked whether she had given the Duck a name. Ege felt uncomfortable naming the Duck as one would a human or pet, as this was not the relationship she was looking to develop. For this paper, we decided to capitalize the "D" in reference to the Duck, as we would do with names of humans as an anthropomorphic compromise. This also allowed us to not use a pronoun for the Duck (he, she or it).

might be missed by focusing solely on successful outcomes. There is no direct way of asking questions or gathering feedback from non-humans, as we would with humans. Therefore, the attempts to involve non-human agencies in design processes, an ongoing work of staying with the trouble [27], make the process prone to uncertainties. Design projects grappling with more-than-human agencies might lead designers to reevaluate their aims, processes, approaches, and change trajectories [45]. In this work, we welcomed uncertainty in the process and expected, if not committed, to have misunderstandings and failures. Therefore, despite the mundaneness and seeming simplicity of the task of sharing a park bench, Ege kept coming back to the Duck for six weeks. The aim was not whether Ege was successful in sharing a bench with the Duck (though it would have been great) but instead to understand Ege's decentered, porous, and horizontal position better through the process and its many twists, turns and humbling rejections of the Duck

3 Horizontality as a generative lens

Wakkary offers the concept of horizontality as part of his framework of *design-with* [65] that positions design practice as relational to more-than-human interdependencies and agencies. The idea of a designer does not refer only to humans but includes more-than-human beings that are part of the design process. The design-with concept requires a radical shift in how we design and think. Part of this shift is a position of horizontality as a “*metaphor for embodied generosity*” [65:251]. We are drawn to this term for two reasons. First, it speaks to human positionality in space, which is aligned with our starting prompt to share a park bench with the Duck. Second, as mentioned earlier, we see the challenges of decentering human perspectives in design as a horizon. Horizontality is about rejecting the metaphorical vertical positioning of humans among non-humans, a top-down view favouring humans. Wakkary describes this proposition of **non-hierarchy** as “*a fall to the ground*” [65:251]. It can be a starting point of *designing-with* that accounts for less hierarchical relations and generosity. Through this fall, the more-than-human assembly becomes closer, and their **contact points expand**. Adopting this approach creates **proximity** and **increased relationality**. However, there is also a risk in adopting this approach. The human designer might lose the overview of relations that are not visible in a horizontal position. “*The embrace of everything can become an embrace of nothing.*” [65:252] says Wakkary. This can open up **vulnerabilities** for the designer. Wakkary sees it as “*a cautious way forward*” [65:252] instead of a solution and highlights the importance of **humility** in adopting a horizontal positioning. We will use these concepts to reflect on Ege's encounters with the Duck. As a cautious way forward to posthuman subjectivity through the lens of horizontality, the process is marked by numerous failed attempts and an exploratory approach to designing for sharing space with the Duck. Through this analysis, we contribute an example of working with the concept of horizontality.

4 Duck Encounters

This project was part in the School for Multispecies Knowledges, (organized by zone2source and Open Set), a residency program that

took place in Amstelpark in Amsterdam. Participants from various backgrounds visited the park frequently developing their projects and visiting in lectures and workshops. The program had an open structure that encouraged “*to explore together how we can better tune into the multiple scales and imageries of urban co-existences and co-dependencies of diverse living and technological organisms*” [68]. Ege applied as an industrial and speculative designer with the aim to research the positions from which designers share space with more-than-humans. Curious about a wide range of possibilities of sharing space and encountering different flora and fauna in the park, she was looking at ways to *become-with* the park. Ege wanted a flexible framework for further developing her practice and transforming herself. When her application got accepted, she stayed in Amsterdam with an open mind to see what the park and its more-than-human entanglements would teach her. The Duck arose as a central figure early on in the program. Ege noticed how the ducks and geese use the benches at the waterside as a perching area. Specifically, there was one Muscovy Duck with distinct and easily recognizable visual features. The Duck constantly walked around the participants and other park visitors, while the other ducks and the geese seemed to care less, or not at all, about humans. Soon, the Duck was known among all the participants of the residency program.

She set out to design encounters with the Duck to explore alternative ways of sharing space, with a special focus on the spatial and horizontal opportunities of the park bench. To start her work, she directed a question to the Duck: *May I share a park bench with you?* Ege was aware of many of the anthropocentric assumptions in this starting point. For example, she didn't know how to ask for permission from the Duck (*May I?*), whether the Duck would be interested in sharing the *park bench*, or even what *sharing* space means for the Duck. The decision to pursue it for six weeks was a way to create a relationship with the Duck and transform her position. Committed to the question, with a humble, open and self-critical mindset, Ege started her process of probing activities, organizing public readings and building structures.

Drawing on Ege's experiences, notes, and photographs of the encounters, both authors analyzed the process through several sessions, reflecting on the instances of horizontality we saw in the encounters. In the next sections, we present these into four narrative themes: *distance*, *comfort*, *time*, and *mimic*. Each section includes a reflection on horizontality. The encounters will be described from Ege's first-person perspective.

4.1 Distance

To investigate the personal distance between me and the Duck, I decide to build a measuring stick. I take Edward Hall's proxemics research as a starting point. Hall says the average personal distance of a human is 1.2m [26]. I wonder what the personal distance for a duck is and how it might change for this Duck. This question seems highly relevant if we are to share a park bench.

I try different ways of interaction while having the stick around and asking someone else to photograph us from a distance. The design of the stick resembles the photo scales commonly used in archaeological photography. This feature helps me examine the distance between the Duck and me when looking at the images afterward.



Figure 2: Ege, trying out the measuring stick with the Duck

In some cases, the Duck and I get much closer than 1.2m. The distance feels closer or farther, depending on the interaction. For example, I feel more comfortable when the Duck approaches me rather than the other way around. By observing the Duck and with the help of background readings, I also understand more about the body language of ducks.

4.1.1 Reflections of horizontality. The measuring stick (Figure 2) was a tool for Ege to determine how close she and the Duck could get to each other to be able to enjoy or at least tolerate each other's company on a park bench. Distance was an important element to consider when sharing a park bench, in itself an attempt towards creating *proximity* and *increased relationality*. It was, of course, impossible to define a general rule about the comfortable distance between the Duck and Ege using only a linear stick. Yet Ege did come to understand her comfortable distance and how it changes in relation to the Duck. For example, Ege's feeling of ease when the Duck approached her, instead of the other way around. Here, Ege accounted for the Duck's navigation of space and agency. This could be seen as an attempt towards *non-hierarchy*. Ege also realized she can never fully grasp the Duck's perspective on the comfortable distance, emphasizing the importance of continued *humility*.

4.2 Comfort

A lot of the park's waterfowl is spending time on the park benches, which are often uncomfortable for humans and so I assume they would also fail to be comfortable as a perching area for birds. Therefore, I set out to explore if I can provide the Duck with more comfort.

I collect branches from the park and build a structure to extend the bench for the Duck to stand on. If the Duck shows no interest, I must dismantle the structure. In anticipation of this, I decide to use materials from the park to avoid introducing possibly unfamiliar or harmful materials to the Duck and the park. It is a long process of making. I peel off the skin of the branches and sand them down to create a smooth surface. Next, I assemble the pieces, build the structure, and transport it back to the park. The extension makes the bench longer, giving the Duck more flexibility in terms of distance.

Feeling somewhat hopeful that the Duck will prefer the custom-built structure instead of the bench, I place the extension in the park and wait for the Duck to try it. The Duck is, maybe for the first time in the residency, not interested at all. Humbled by the Duck's reaction, I dismantle the structure and leave the branches in the park where I first found them.

4.2.1 Reflections of horizontality. As the benches found in parks are presumably designed for human comfort (the degree of comfort can be questioned), Ege's attempt to create an extension (Figure 3) for the Duck was a way to recalibrate the imbalance of comfort availability in the park. The extension was used to create a park bench for the Duck and Ege and, therefore, a material move towards *non-hierarchy*. Additionally, extending the possible places to sit on the bench created possibilities for expanding *contact points*. Although the attempt failed, the idea was to create a literal horizontal space that would create space and serve the needs of both humans and non-humans. The process showed that the bench itself was preferred by the birds, and the custom-built extension was not. The Duck's response reminded Ege to listen. The Duck's refusal allowed her to acknowledge the more-than-human agency. This created a moment of *humility* that further challenges human-centered assumptions about comfort in shared spaces and the necessity for creating opportunities for refusal.

4.3 Time

The more time I spend in the park, the more curious I become about times when I am not there. I wonder what the Duck is doing at night, or when the Duck wakes up. I want to get to know the Duck's routine better.

I visit the park at midnight and dawn, hoping to understand the Duck's routine better. Being present, however, appearing sleepy, the Duck does not seem to care to see me during these hours. I keep my visits short.

The different meanings of the park for me and the Duck become more concrete after these off-hours visits. It is the Duck's home, and I am just visiting. The encounters do not allow me to grasp the Duck's



Figure 3: Ege, waiting for the Duck to try the bench extension



Figure 4: Left: The Duck at 23:41; Right: The Duck at 05:15

routine fully. However, they expand my understanding of the multi-species routines of the park, which are only partially accessible during the daytime.

4.3.1 Reflections of horizontality. The space was home for the Duck, who shared it with humans (including Ege) for a few hours during the daytime. As an outsider, Ege committed to spending time with the Duck for the duration of the residency. She was entangling herself with the park only in a certain time frame. The off-hour visits (Figure 4) highlighted the different meanings of the space for the Duck and Ege, rendering the Duck as the host and Ege as a visitor. We see this as an example of *expanded contact points* through time. However, in Ege's experience, the distribution of the roles is not horizontal, and rightfully so: the park was not Ege's home. We reflect that this is a moment where horizontality may not be desired. In this encounter, the commitment to expand Ege's perception of the Duck's time and routine enabled further horizontality in their positioning. Although the human perception of the Duck remained fragmented, it was worth pursuing curiosity to allow for this critical reflection. It helped Ege to cultivate an *increased relationality* with the Duck across space and time.

4.4 Mimic

After many moments of witnessing the Duck, I became quite familiar with how the Duck stands, walks, and looks for things. This familiarity left me with an urge to mimic the Duck. I am also inspired by several artistic projects that similarly mimic other life forms [3, 43, 52]. I wonder whether a bodily performative experiment can help me understand the Duck better with a dash of skepticism (I believe the mimicking in this context to be anthropomorphizing and shortsighted).

I collect clothing and accessories to create an outfit that makes me look like the Duck. I put them on in the park and ask a friend to photograph me while I mimic the Duck's behaviors and looks. I decided to do this mimicry exercise without the Duck, because I think this tryout is more about me than our relationship. The Duck's participation in the moment is not necessary.

Not surprisingly, the outfit falls short of helping me to change my perspective into the Duck's. However, when looking through the photographs documenting this act of mimicry, I see a certain degree of self-alienation. To me, it was a necessary step to break free of my usual thinking patterns and start thinking about ways to relate to the Duck.



Figure 5: Ege, mimicking the Duck

4.4.1 Reflections of horizontality. Ege started the mimicking activities (Figure 5) from an ambivalent position: she did not know what this could mean and doubted whether it could work. This was a moment of *vulnerability*. Still, she decided to pursue it, sensing the generative potential of creating a sort of horizontal attunement between her and the Duck. The weirdness that comes through acting as if you are another body and seeing yourself from another perspective makes the connection of porous, more-than-human beings apparent in an embodied way. This porosity *expands contact points* through *increased relationality*. Embracing *humility*, and being open to being wrong enables the generative potential of giving into curious weirdness.

5 Navigating towards horizontality

We used horizontality as a generative lens to evaluate Ege's position in relation to the Duck and the shared space in the park. In our reflection, it was easy to see our **expanded contact points** between Ege and the more-than-humans in the park and how they **increased proximity and relationality** across space and time. As we got closer to the Duck, we thought we understood more about our relationship, and we made ourselves **vulnerable** both during the process and by reporting on it. The analysis also helped us to see the transformative moments, that were full of insightful learnings but also, as expected, full of misunderstandings and failed attempts, leaving us **humbled** multiple times. Applying these terms to an actual design project to become a posthuman subject enabled us to uncover the activities and approaches related to horizontality when sharing space with non-humans. While these terms helped us to dive into the work through the analytical lens of horizontality, they also showed us that horizontality can be understood in multiple ways, and there is a need to understand its nuances to work with these differences. Therefore, we offer three additional dimensions of horizontality: **spatial**, **agential**, and **temporal**.

Spatial horizontality within the park includes, for example, the experiments with the measuring stick, which led Ege to move her body to positions close to the Duck and the Duck's eye level. Or the bench extension was positioned adjacent to the bench, increasing

the horizontal distance between Ege and the Duck. Looking at Ege's process, we argue that these bodily engagements in proximity helped Ege change her spatial orientation and immerse herself more in the world of the Duck. This bodily proximity created the common ground between them for Ege to work on the metaphorical orientation toward horizontality.

Agential horizontality became apparent in the many moments in which the Duck acted unexpectedly. When we reflected on Ege's activities, we saw that this was present in many ways as a direction towards. For example, the park bench was designed only for humans, creating an imbalance of power. By building the extension, Ege wanted to create a non-hierarchical park bench that accounts for human and non-human needs. The Duck, by showing no interest in the custom-built structure, made us also acknowledge the agency of non-humans, leading us to understand how **agential horizontality** can be enacted through refusal.

Finally, **temporal horizontality** was present in several encounters where Ege challenged her own temporalities. Most clearly, when Ege visited the Duck at midnight and dawn. These activities made Ege move to the proximity of the Duck during times when they were usually apart. Temporal horizontality allowed Ege to see different rhythms in the park and how aligning those might bring new insights into their relationality.

Spatial, agential, and temporal horizontality should be seen as dimensions that we generated in our work to carve out horizontality as a concept for designers sharing space with non-humans. They are porous and open-ended, and we offer them here as additional dimensions on our continued cautious way forward toward becoming posthuman subjects.

6 Discussion

In the discussion, we first elaborate on how our additional dimensions of horizontality can be explored further in more-than-human design. Then, we elaborate on humility and asking polite questions and how they helped us in our journey of becoming posthuman subjects.

6.1 Mobilizing horizontality

Expanding on *spatial horizontality*, we found the setting of the residency program provided a fruitful opportunity for Ege to develop a more horizontal position towards the space they shared with the Duck. Residency programs have long been an important part of creative practices and within HCI have been applied to interdisciplinary collaboration between design, arts, science and/or crafts [18, 19, 53]. We see potential for more-than-human design research in HCI to organize and participate in residencies, enabling researchers to entangle and design-with the multispecies surroundings, developing deeper connections to shared spaces. We encourage you to commit to spatial horizontality: getting your hands dirty with soil, swimming in waters, or living and sleeping in fields you are working with to develop situated perspectives toward familiar or unknown shared multispecies spaces.

Visiting the park during unusual hours was a simple but influential starting point toward *temporal horizontality*. In light of ongoing work about temporality in more-than-human design [5, 11, 30, 47, 55], we are inspired to think of ways to challenge human clock time. Developing horizontality towards other temporalities might mean adjusting or challenging our temporal framings regarding entities with which we share spaces, such as a 300-year-old tree in our neighbourhood, a melting glacier, or our microbiome. Being awake at night, visiting unfamiliar spots, or perhaps even fasting might be small first steps to align ourselves with slower, faster, or unusual temporalities.

Lastly, in relation to agential horizontality, we want to acknowledge the challenge of recognizing more-than-human agencies in their refusal. In our work, the lack of the Duck's interest in the custom-built structure led us to question our designerly reflexes. Instead of iterating to (presumptively) improve the structure, we listened to non-human voices and halted our pursuit. This taught us that recognizing more-than-human agencies is not only about noticing them in our surroundings. More importantly, agencies can be revealed by looking closely at what the non-human doesn't do or refuses to do (see also, for example [9]). We argue more work is needed to create encounters in which nonhumans can refuse participation, remain mundane, dormant.

6.2 Adopting humility through polite questions

In this work, the simple act of asking a question (*May I share a park bench with you?*) and committing to it for six weeks proved to be valuable in shifting the designer's position. This question started our cautious way forward to develop a relationship with the Duck while trying to share space. It left us humbled on multiple occasions. This careful space for experimenting through design revealed ways of seeing ourselves as posthuman subjects.

Philosopher Vinciane Despret highlights the importance of asking the right questions to animals in ethology, for whom the virtue of politeness is an epistemological commitment [17]. Despret is informed by the work of ethologist Thema Rowell with sheep, who asks research questions that allow the sheep to act differently than expected. For example, Despret talks about Rowell's experiment in which she feeds 22 sheep with 23 bowls of food to offer the sheep the opportunity to behave differently than what is usually observed in ethology, focusing on competition. Despret explains

the additional bowl: “*The role of this ethology is legible in this emblematic twenty-third bowl: it is responsible for inventing, with the generosity of intelligence, polite ways of entering into relationships with non-humans.*” [17:368]

Although we started with a polite question of entering into a relationship with the Duck, Ege and the Duck did not, in the end, use the park bench simultaneously. Still, the process allowed us to learn and unlearn with the Duck, to challenge our relationship, and to question our designerly reflexes. This created a framework of humility, which we used to orient ourselves on cautious steps toward horizontalizing our approach. Taylor grounds the work of Despret in design by stating that the stories of Despret can inspire opportunities through design “*for more sympathetic, richer, and more expansive ways of becoming together*” [60:36]. Following this line of thought, our question leads us toward horizontal *becoming together* in which the way of asking embraces generosity. In this direction, more work that asks polite questions that welcome humility, opening up to a multiplicity of outcomes in relation to non-humans is needed, be it sheep, bees, stray dogs, ducks, or maybe the Duck.

7 Conclusion

This project started with a simple question of trying to share a park bench with a specific Duck in Amstelpark, Amsterdam. Ege created several tools and approaches to share the space with the Duck. We use Wakkary's horizontality as a lens to analyze encounters with the Duck and how they helped us become posthuman subjects. Horizontality accounts for repositioning the human designer alongside more-than-human beings to move away from dominant human perspectives in design processes. Our analysis enabled us to identify key nuances and deeper insights that help carve out processes and activities for horizontalizing the designer. We compile our findings by offering three additional dimensions of horizontality: **spatial**, **agential**, and **temporal**. These terms can help design researchers and educators create activities to experiment with alternative multispecies relations. We have also discussed how art and design residencies and adjusting to different rhythms can provide HCI researchers with settings to create horizontal connections across space and time with the more-than-human world.

To create a horizontal approach towards non-human agencies, researchers should pay more attention to what nonhumans refuse to do. We argue that this requires not only a different, decentered approach in design but one in research too: we need radically new ways to understand how little we can know. This is the value of committing to six weeks of unsuccessful pursuits with a Duck in the park. Here, we want to remind our readers how Wakkary offered horizontality as “*a metaphor for embodied generosity*” [65:251]. Our starting motivation was to explore horizontal ways of sharing space with non-human living bodies to become posthuman subjects. Given the rapid destruction of natural habitats due to climate crisis and ever-expanding urbanization, more animals are moving to cities, expanding the points of contact with humans. Adopting a generous approach to sharing space is more than just weird, silly, or cute: it is **urgent** in our multispecies environments.

We see our work as one step towards welcoming horizontality in more-than-human design. The concept opens up new dimensions

or completely new horizons to help us with the shift to more-than-human-centered computing that is underway in HCI. Yet, more work is required to mobilize the concept of horizontality. We encourage others to commit to studies that invite humility, weirdness, politeness and refusal in more-than-human worlds. **Go to the park! Follow your Ducks!**

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